
The ...Qa5 core repertoire

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-01 - Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo.

RECOGNITION TEST

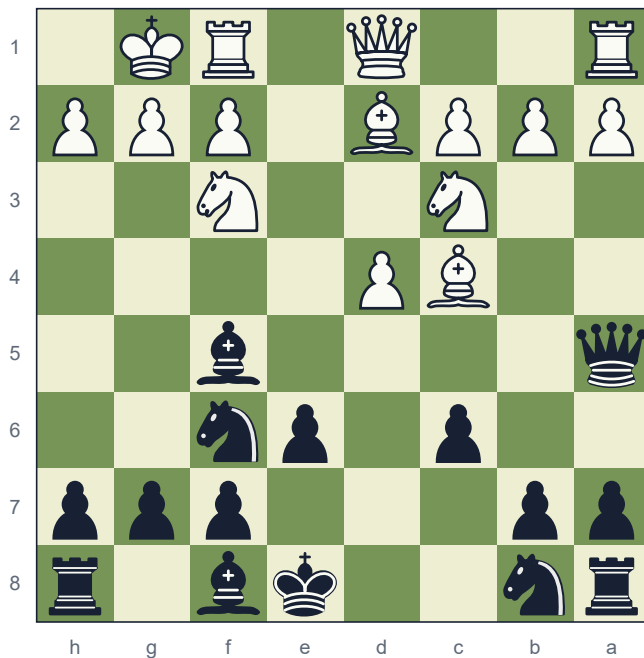
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-01 / The classical development route

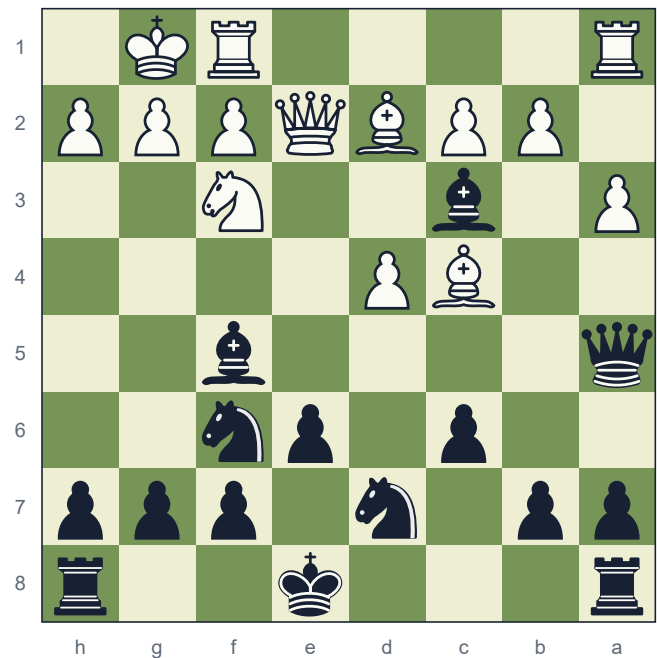
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Bd2 e6 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bb4 10. a3 Bxc3

Authored anchor ends after 8... Nbd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo.

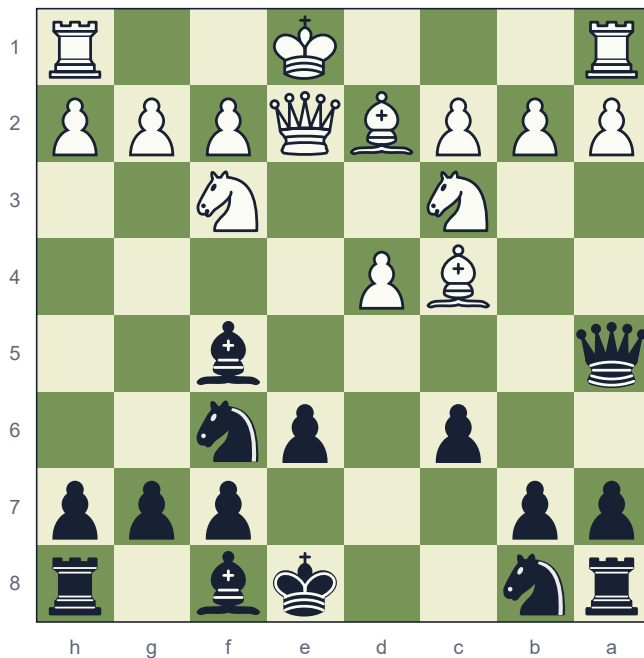
REMEMBER Develop the bishop before locking it in.

SC-02 / White uses Qe2 and long castling

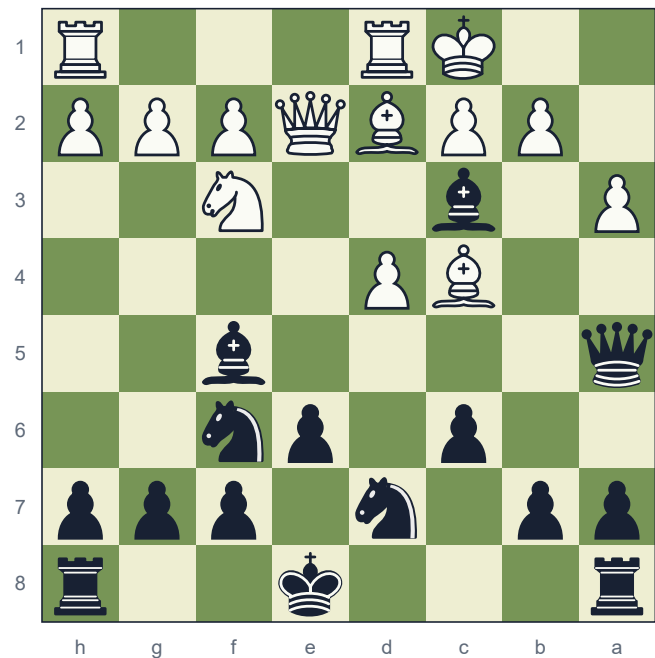
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Bd2 e6 8. Qe2 Bb4 9. a3 Nbd7 10. O-O-O Bxc3

Authored anchor ends after 8... Bb4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Qe2 prepares long castling and increases central pressure. ...Bb4 develops with a concrete relation to the c3 knight rather than immediately making another pawn move.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development and decide whether the queen should retreat before castling. If kings go to opposite wings, count attack tempi rather than following a fixed pawn storm.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can play O-O-O and advance the kingside pawns. Opening the center while your own king remains on e8 can be dangerous.

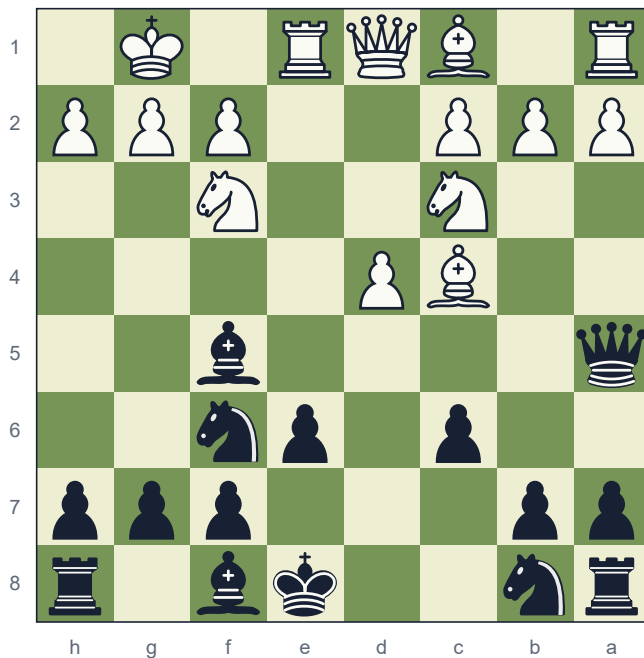
REMEMBER The king choice changes the race.

SC-03 / White castles short early

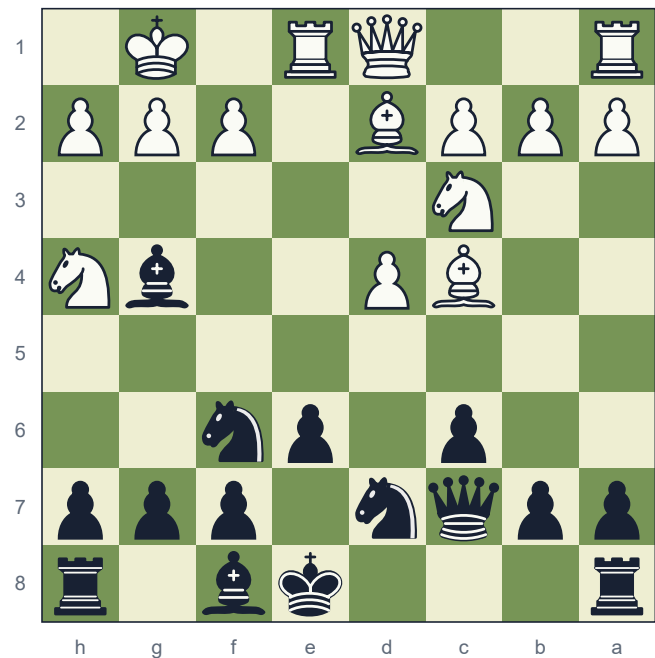
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. O-O e6 8. Re1 Nbd7 9. Bd2 Qc7 10. Nh4 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 8... Nbd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Re1 creates pressure on the e-file while Black is still developing. The black king and queen bishop must be coordinated before the center opens.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Be7 or ...Bb4 when safe, then castle. Check whether e6 is pinned or overworked before recapturing in the center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it.

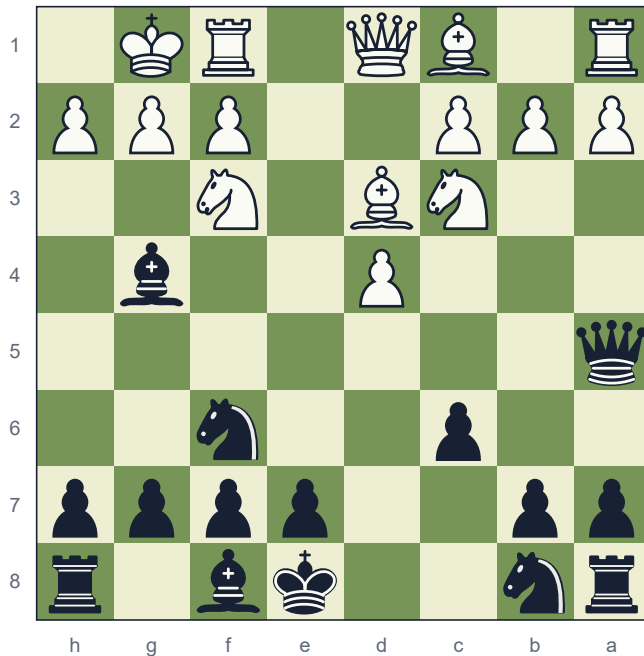
REMEMBER An open e-file is a development deadline.

SC-04 / White puts the bishop on d3

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bd3 Bg4 7. O-O e6 8. h3 Bh5 9. Bf4 Qd8 10. Re1 Bd6

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Bd3 aims at h7 and supports central control. ...Bg4 develops actively against Nf3, reducing one possible supporter of e5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nbd7 and the king bishop, then choose king safety. If ...Bxf3 is considered, compare White's recapture and the resulting bishop pair.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Bxh7+ motifs depend on the king position and supporting pieces. Do not create a hook with ...h6 or ...g6 without checking the attacking consequences.

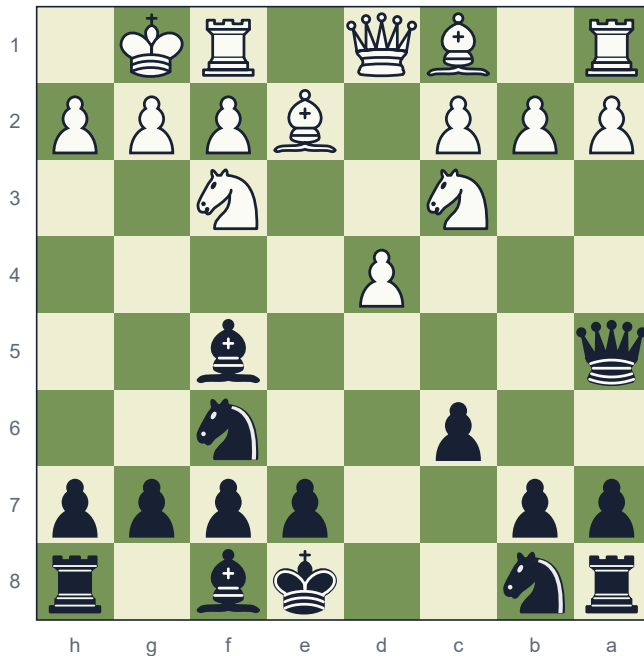
REMEMBER Respect the bishop diagonal before weakening king cover.

SC-05 / White develops quietly with Be2

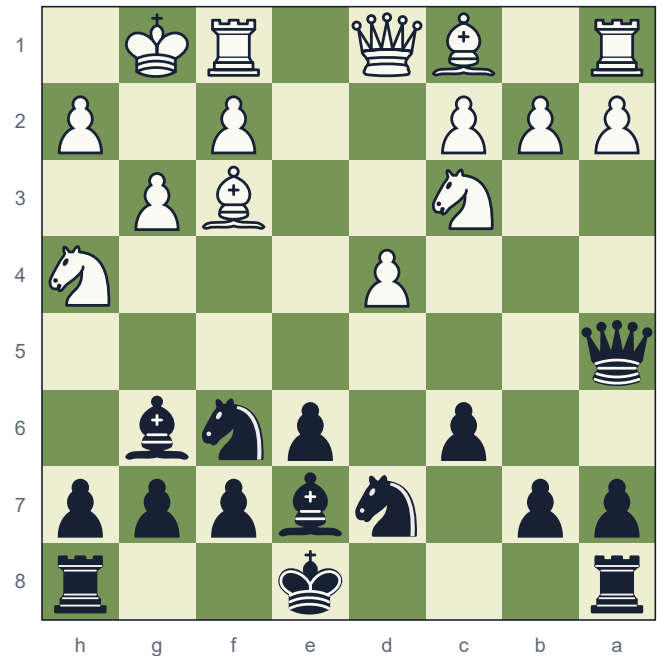
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Be2 Bf5 7. O-O e6 8. Nh4 Bg6 9. g3 Be7 10. Bf3 Nbd7

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White chooses modest development instead of immediate bishop pressure on f7. Black can complete a sound formation while retaining central counterplay.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nbd7 and ...Be7, castle, then seek a justified pawn break. Exchanging one pair of pieces often helps the side with less space.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Quiet development may prepare Ne5 or Nh4. Do not drift into several queen moves just because there is no immediate attack.

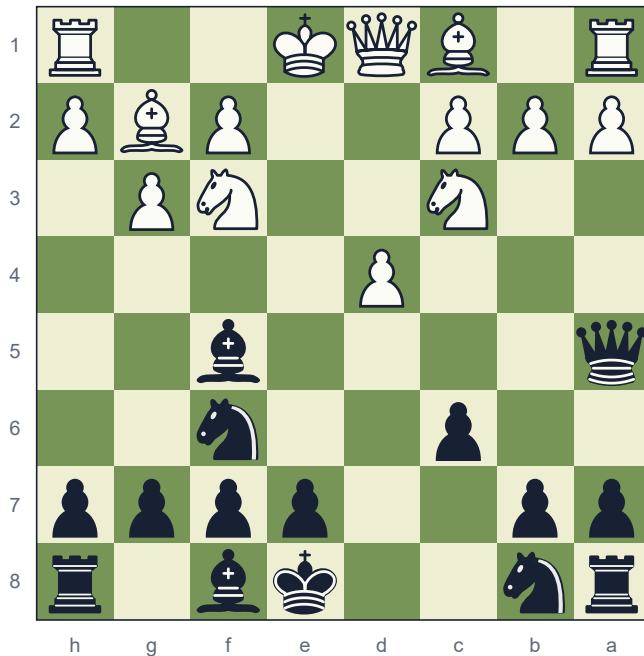
REMEMBER Use the quiet phase to finish development.

SC-06 / White fianchettoes

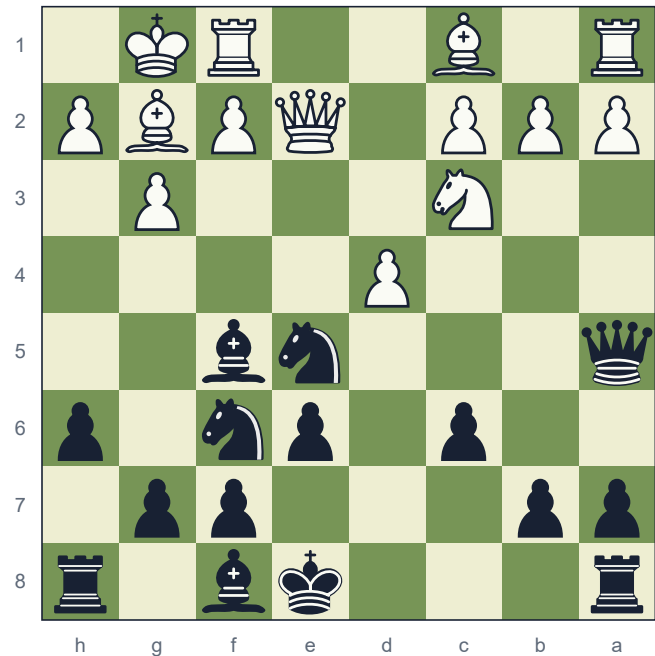
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. g3 Bf5 7. Bg2 e6 8. O-O h6 9. Ne5 Nbd7 10. Qe2 Nxe5

Authored anchor ends after 8. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The g2 bishop puts long-term pressure on the center and queenside. Black should develop while monitoring when the diagonal becomes open.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Place the king bishop and knight, castle safely and contest d5. ...h6 can preserve Bf5 only if its time cost and king-safety effects are acceptable.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can exchange central pawns and expose b7. A queen on a5 does not defend every queenside target.

REMEMBER Long diagonals become dangerous when the center clears.

Work through SC-01

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... NBD7

Develops the queen knight while keeping the c-pawn free and adding influence over e5 and c5.

9... BB4

Places the bishop on b4, attacking knight on c3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... BXC3

The bishop captures a knight on c3. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5. Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Active White systems and queen safety

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-07 - ...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7 when safe, or exchange the active knight if that improves coordination. Keep the queen away from discovered attacks.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White may play g4 against Bf5. The bishop needs a safe square and the queen may become a second tactical target.

RECOGNITION TEST

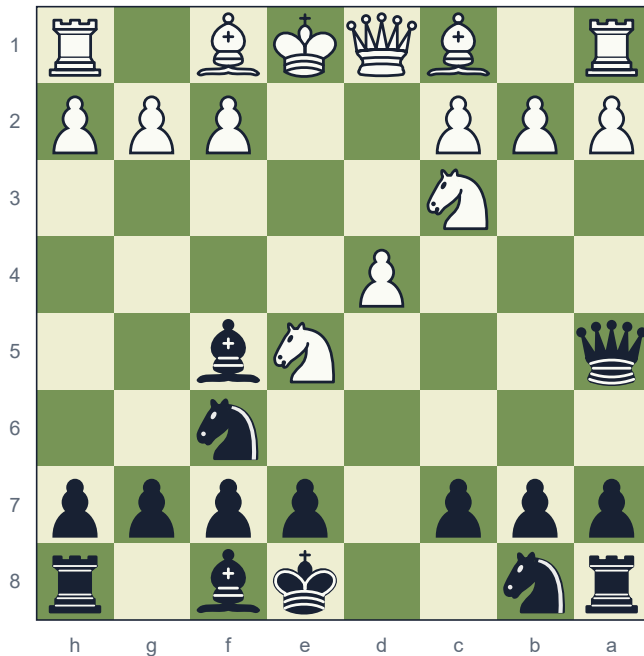
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-07 / White attacks Bf5 with Ne5

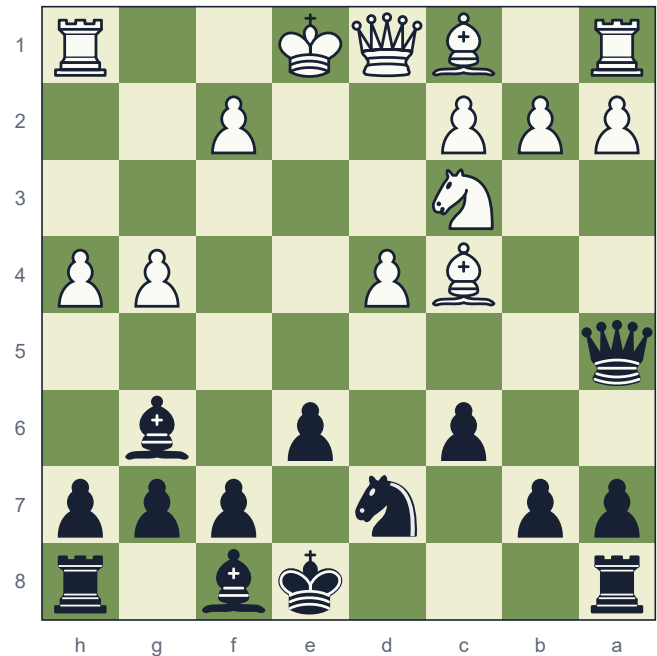
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 Bf5 6. Ne5 c6 7. Bc4 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4 Nbd7 10. Nxd7 Nxd7

Authored anchor ends after 6... c6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7 when safe, or exchange the active knight if that improves coordination. Keep the queen away from discovered attacks.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may play g4 against Bf5. The bishop needs a safe square and the queen may become a second tactical target.

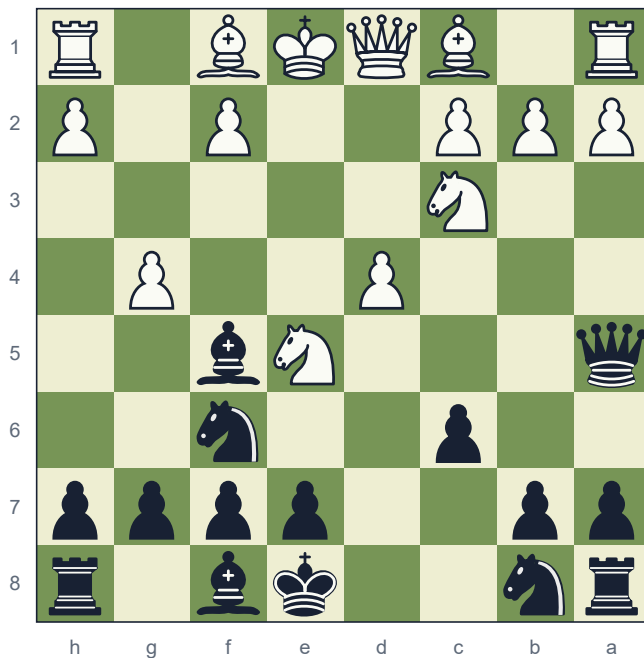
REMEMBER Two attacked pieces can turn a pawn push into a tactic.

SC-08 / White pushes g4 against the bishop

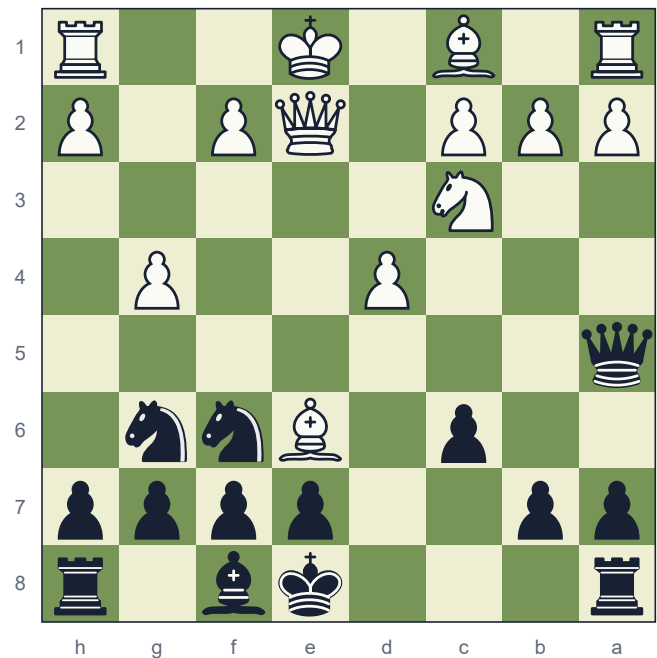
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 Bf5 6. Ne5 c6 7. g4 Be6 8. Bc4 Nbd7 9. Bxe6 Nxe5 10. Qe2 Ng6

Authored anchor ends after 7... Be6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Be6 saves the bishop and avoids the immediate h4 chase that can follow a retreat to g6. The engine comparison favors this retreat in the exact position shown.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and inspect the center before counterattacking the advanced pawns. Keep the queen safe from discovered attacks as White's knight moves.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position.

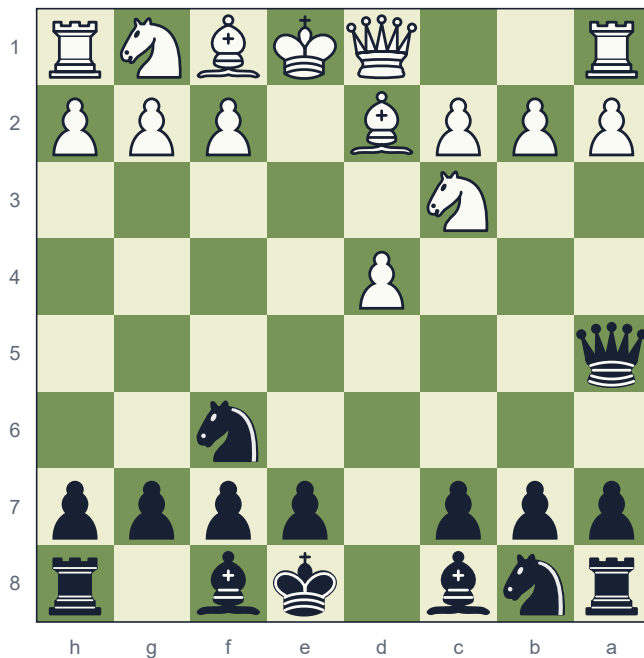
REMEMBER Compare the bishop's whole escape route.

SC-09 / An immediate Bd2 hits the queen

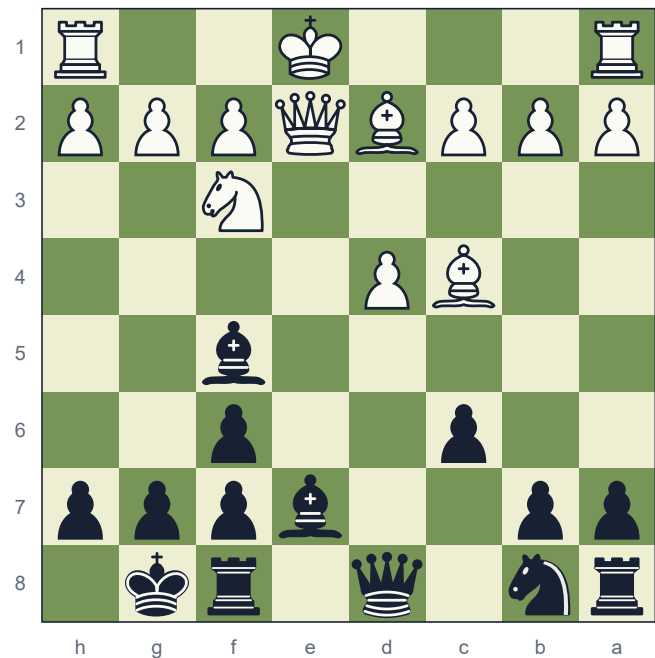
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Bd2 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Nd5 Qd8 8. Nxf6+ exf6 9. Qe2+ Be7 10. Nf3 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 5... c6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Bd2 creates a potential discovered attack along the d2-a5 diagonal when Nc3 moves. ...c6 supplies a retreat and limits Nb5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Watch every move of Nc3: it can reveal an attack on the queen. Develop ...Bf5 and ...e6 only after checking the queen's actual safety.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Nd5 or Ne4 can be both a central move and a discovered queen attack. A familiar setup does not exempt you from that calculation.

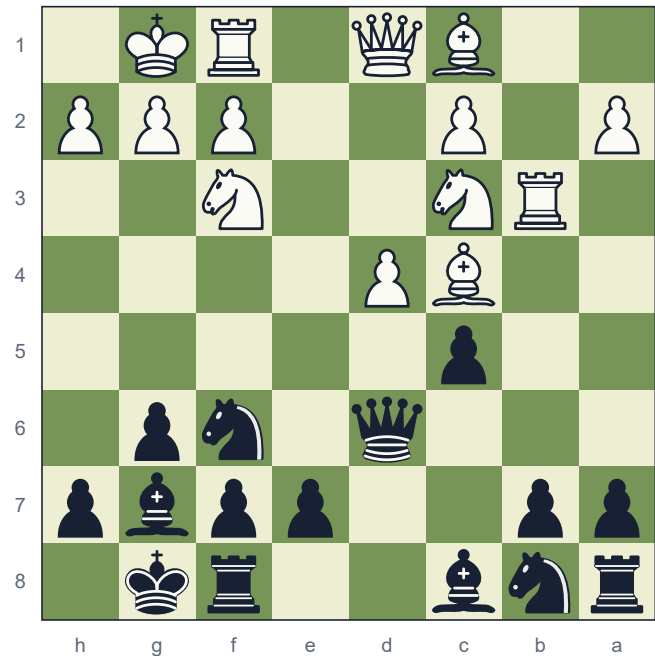
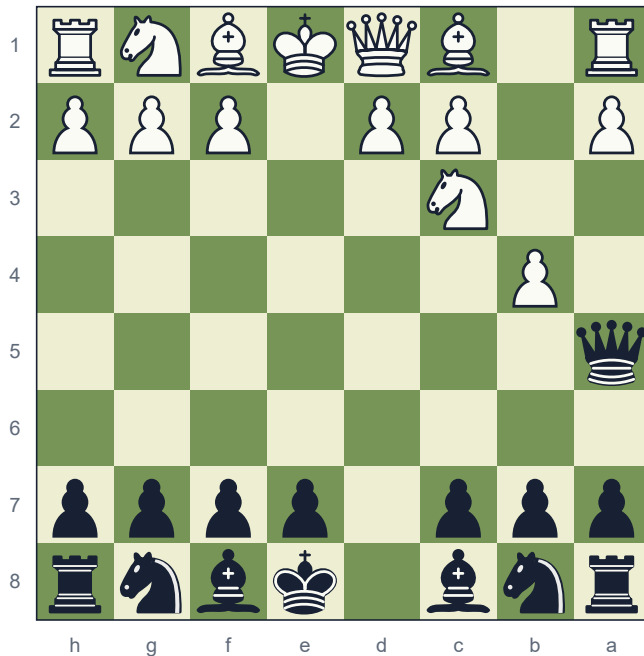
REMEMBER Every c3-knight move may uncover a queen attack.

SC-10 / The b4 pawn offer

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. b4 Qxb4 5. Rb1 Qd6 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. d4 g6 8. Bc4 Bg7 9. O-O O-O 10. Rb3 c5

Authored anchor ends after 4... Qxb4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black can accept the offered pawn, but the queen now faces a series of developing attacks. This is a concrete branch that deserves calculation before practical use.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Find safe queen squares and develop quickly. Return the extra pawn if that gets the king safe and prevents the queen being trapped.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Rb1, Nb5 and developing bishops may gain tempi. Counting only the extra pawn ignores the cost of the queen's excursion.

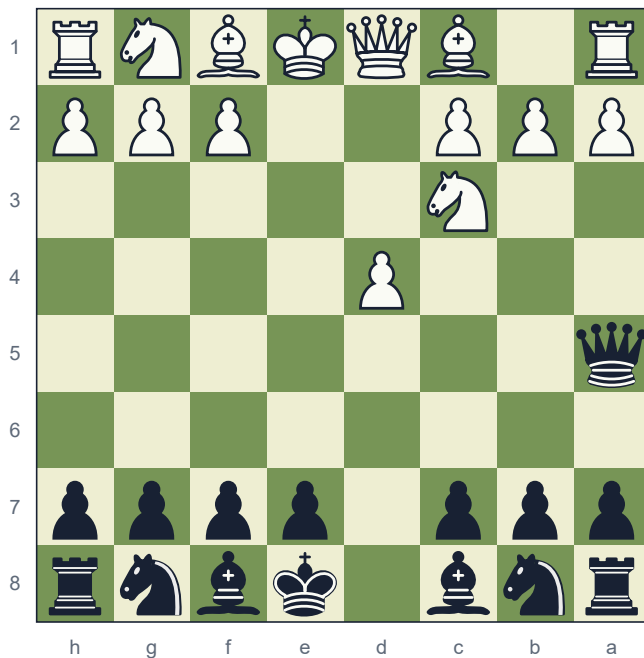
REMEMBER Queen safety can be worth more than retaining a gambit pawn.

SC-11 / White advances d5 early

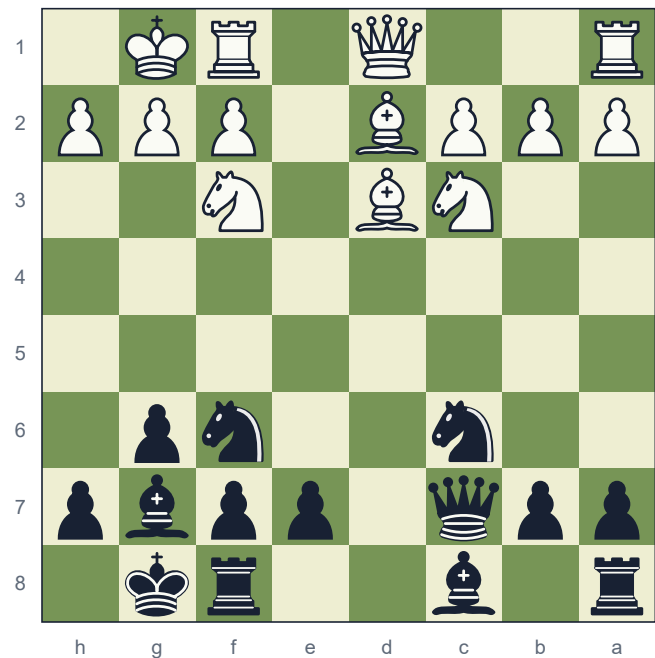
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. d5 c6 6. Bd2 Qc7 7. dxc6 Nxc6 8. Nf3 g6 9. Bd3 Bg7 10. O-O O-O

Authored anchor ends after 5. d5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The advanced d-pawn gains space and restricts Black's queen knight. Black must challenge the wedge or develop around it.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Examine ...c6 and the resulting dxc6 recapture. Seek active development with a clear route for the queen and the f8 bishop.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can support the pawn and gain further space. A slow sequence of waiting moves may leave Black permanently cramped.

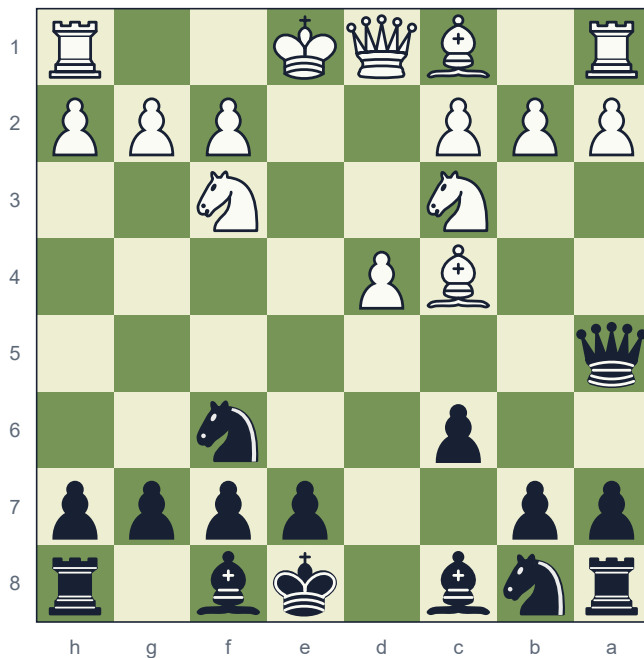
REMEMBER A wedge must be challenged or blockaded deliberately.

SC-12 / White plays Bc4 before Nf3

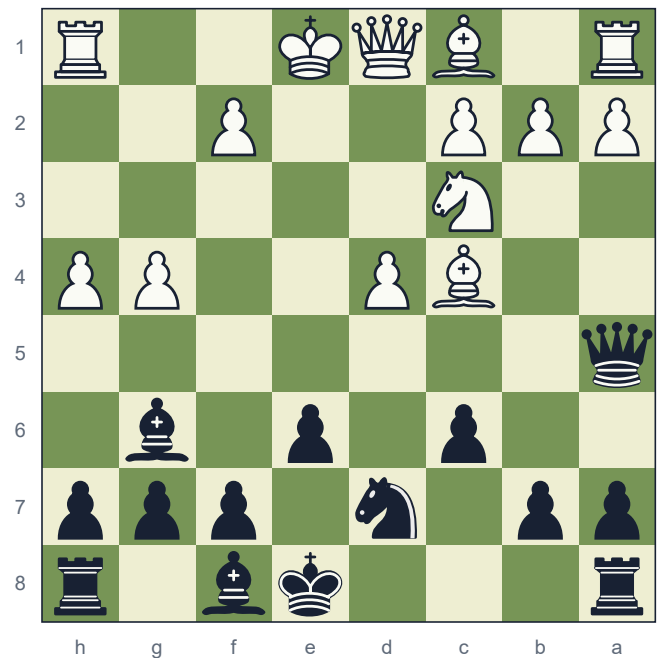
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. Bc4 Nf6 5. d4 c6 6. Nf3 Bf5 7. Ne5 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4 Nbd7 10. Nxd7 Nxd7

Authored anchor ends after 6... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The early bishop makes f7 pressure visible sooner, but the position can transpose to the main route after Nf3. Black should recognize the transposition without ignoring immediate checks.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7, checking whether a bishop or knight sacrifice on f7 has real support. Castle once the position is ready.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An early bishop move can combine with a fast queen move. Do not capture an apparently loose central pawn without considering checks.

REMEMBER Compare exact piece positions before calling a transposition.

Work through SC-07

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... BG6

Places the bishop on g6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... NBD7

Places the knight on d7, attacking knight on e5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... NXD7

The knight captures a knight on d7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight. Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7 when safe, or exchange the active knight if that improves coordination. Keep the queen away from discovered attacks.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

White avoids the main route

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-13 - White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the king side and decide whether ...e6 or ...Bg4 best fits White's setup. Attack the pawn chain rather than automatically bringing the queen out.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

RECOGNITION TEST

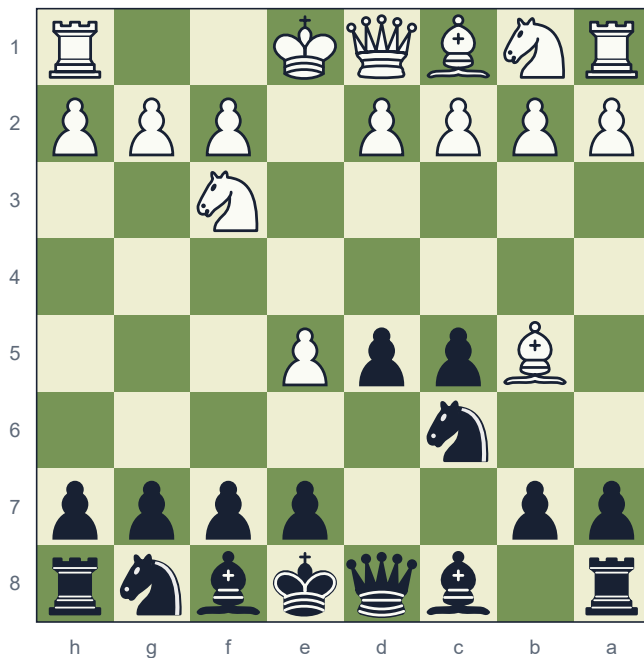
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-13 / White advances with 2.e5

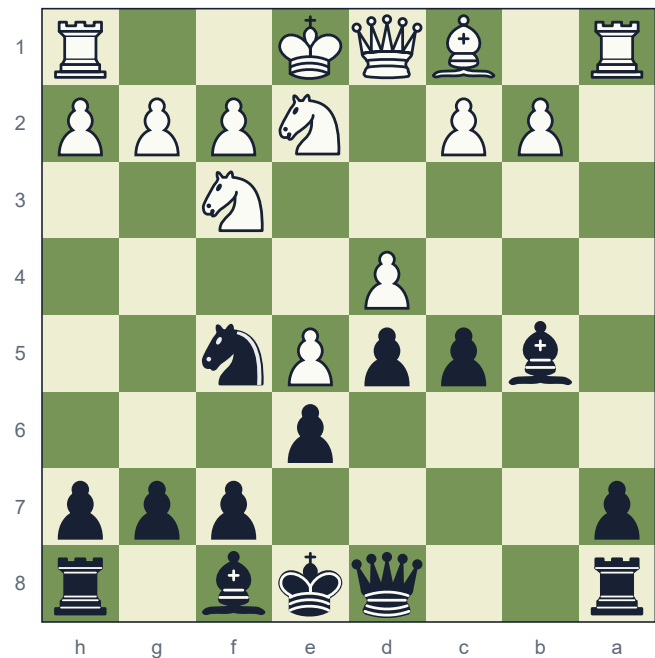
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. e5 c5 3. Nf3 Nc6 4. Bb5 Bd7 5. Bxc6 Bxc6 6. d4 e6 7. Nc3 Ne7 8. Ne2 Nf5 9. a4 b5 10. axb5 Bxb5

Authored anchor ends after 4... Bd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the king side and decide whether ...e6 or ...Bg4 best fits White's setup. Attack the pawn chain rather than automatically bringing the queen out.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

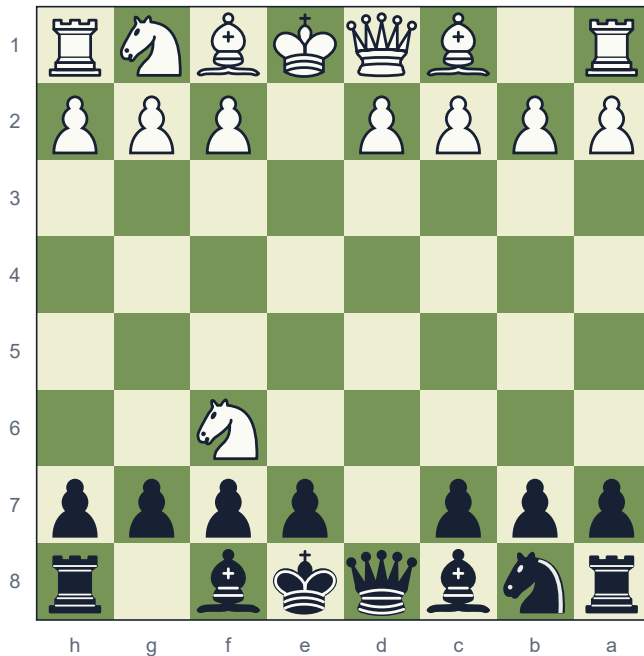
REMEMBER The Scandinavian queen plan belongs to the exchange structure.

SC-14 / White defends with 2.Nc3

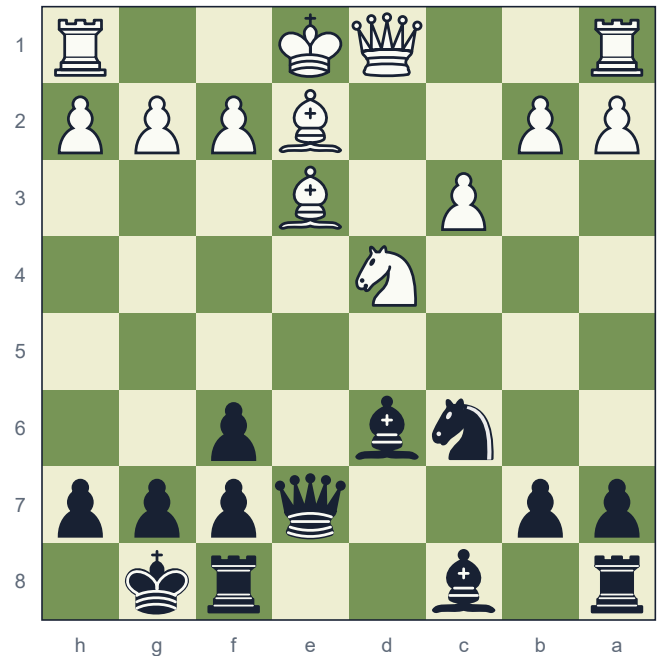
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. Nc3 dxe4 3. Nxe4 Nf6 4. Nxf6+ exf6 5. d4 Bd6 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2 c5 8. Be3 cxd4 9. Nxd4 Nc6 10. c3 Qe7

Authored anchor ends after 4... exf6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges the central pawn and accepts doubled f-pawns in return for development and open lines. The position has its own structure and is not a ...Qa5 line.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops actively, castle safely and consider ...c5. The bishop pair and central access can compensate for imperfect pawn shape.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can target the f-pawns in an endgame. Do not exchange active bishops automatically while keeping only the structural weakness.

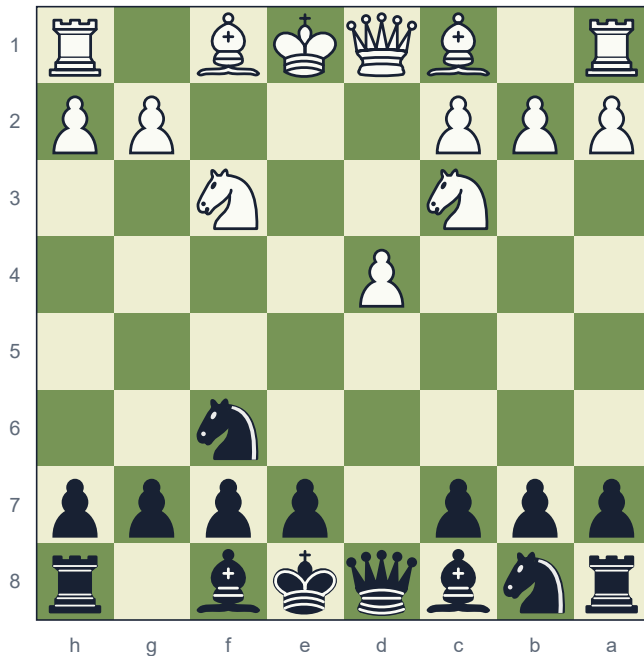
REMEMBER A structural concession needs active pieces in return.

SC-15 / White offers the Blackmar-Diemer

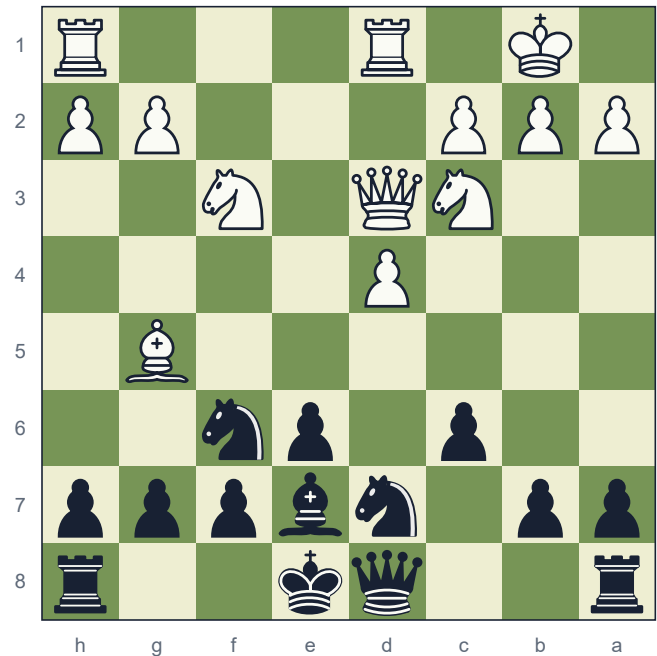
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. d4 dxe4 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. f3 exf3 5. Nxf3 Bf5 6. Bd3 Bxd3 7. Qxd3 c6 8. Bg5 e6 9. O-O-O Nbd7 10. Kb1 Be7

Authored anchor ends after 5... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White offers a pawn for development and open attacking lines. ...Bf5 develops before ...e6 and makes the extra material easier to defend.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development, castle when safe and return the pawn if necessary to neutralize the initiative. Keep f7 and the central files under observation.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Bc4, Ne5 and Qe2 against a slow defense. Greedy pawn grabbing while the king stays central is the main practical danger.

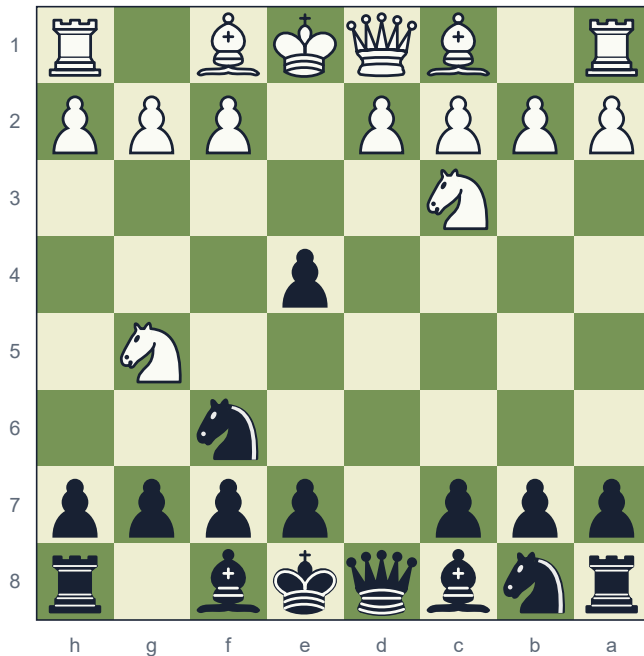
REMEMBER Against a gambit, make the extra pawn easy to live with.

SC-16 / White plays 2.Nf3

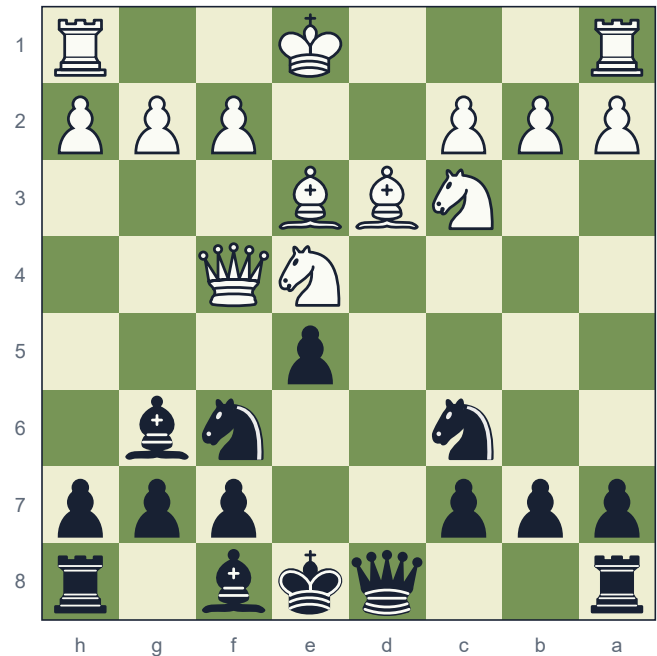
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. Nf3 dxe4 3. Ng5 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. d3 Bg4 6. Qd2 exd3 7. Bxd3 Nc6 8. Qf4 Bh5 9. Nge4 Bg6 10. Be3 e5

Authored anchor ends after 4... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black accepts the central pawn and develops with support for e4. White attacks quickly with knights and hopes to recover material with tempi.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...e6 and the king bishop, checking tactical pressure on f7. If the pawn costs too much time to hold, return it for safe development.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Nxf7 and threats against the queen can appear. The e4 pawn is not a prize worth losing castling or a piece.

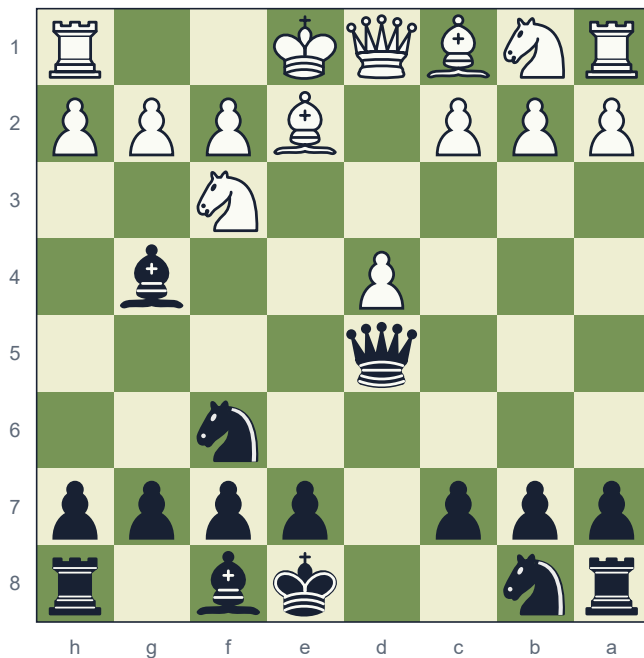
REMEMBER Defend with development when possible.

SC-17 / White recaptures space with 3.d4

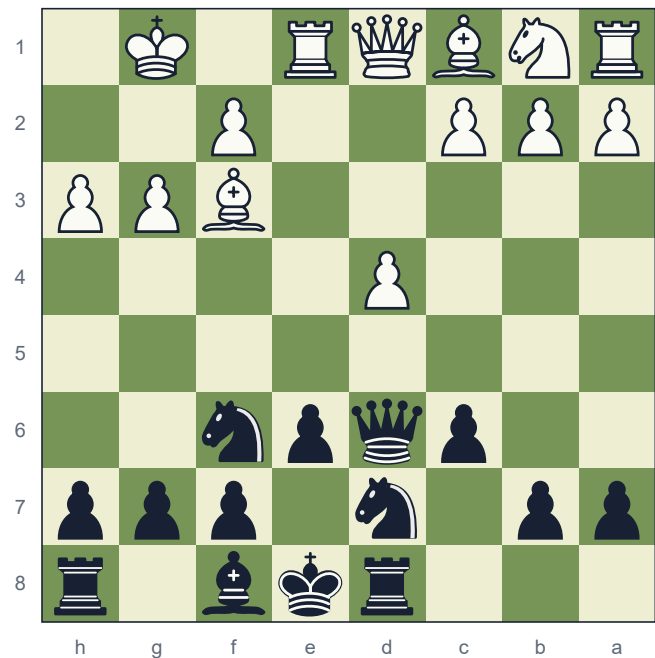
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. d4 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bg4 5. Be2 e6 6. h3 Bxf3 7. Bxf3 Qd6 8. O-O c6 9. g3 Nbd7 10. Re1 Rd8

Authored anchor ends after 5... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White does not attack the queen immediately. Black develops the knight and bishop, keeping the queen flexible rather than committing to a retreat without a threat.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nc6 or ...Nbd7 according to the center and castle safely. Notice if Nc3 later gains a tempo with a discovered threat.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can play c4 to chase the queen while supporting d4. Keep safe retreat squares before making a pawn commitment.

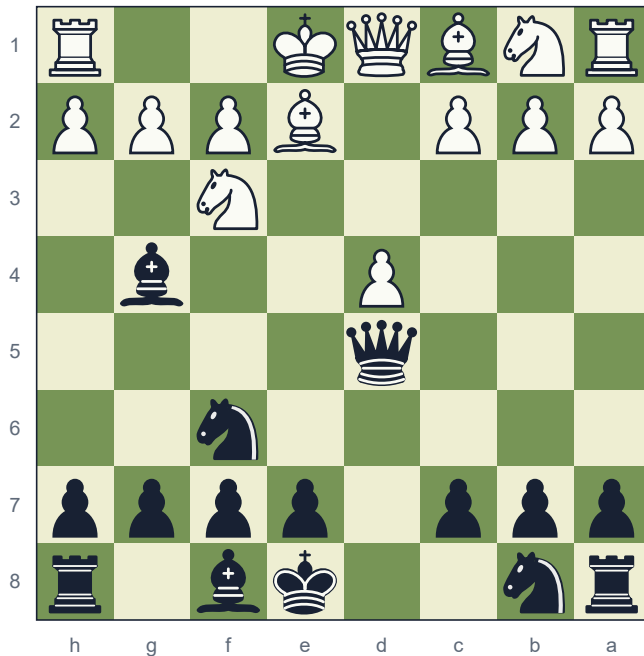
REMEMBER A queen needs an escape route even before it is attacked.

SC-18 / White chooses 3.Nf3

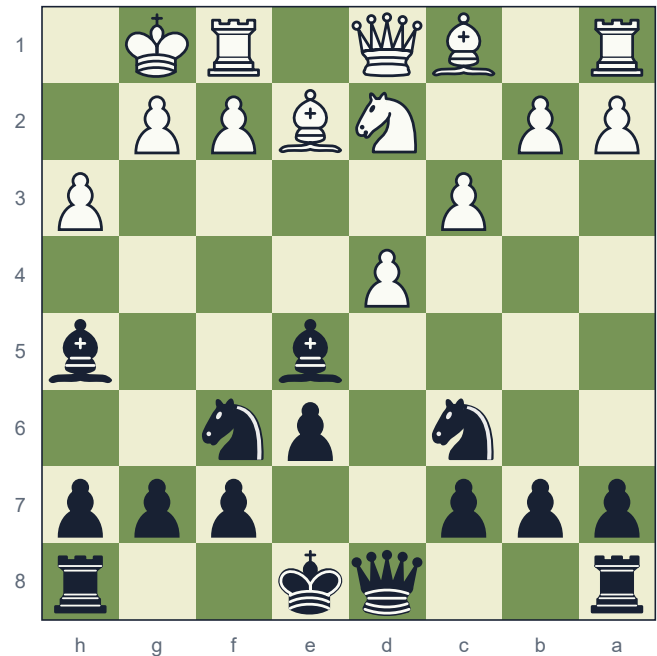
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. d4 Bg4 5. Be2 e6 6. O-O Nc6 7. c3 Qd8 8. h3 Bh5 9. Nbd2 Bd6 10. Ne5 Bxe5

Authored anchor ends after 6. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White postpones Nc3 and c4 while developing. Black can use the time to bring pieces out, but must not assume the queen can remain central forever.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and answer a future c4 or Nc3 with a safe queen retreat. Compare the bishop exchange on f3 before surrendering the bishop pair.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A central queen can be hit by several different pieces. Do not spend the next move on an unrelated wing pawn.

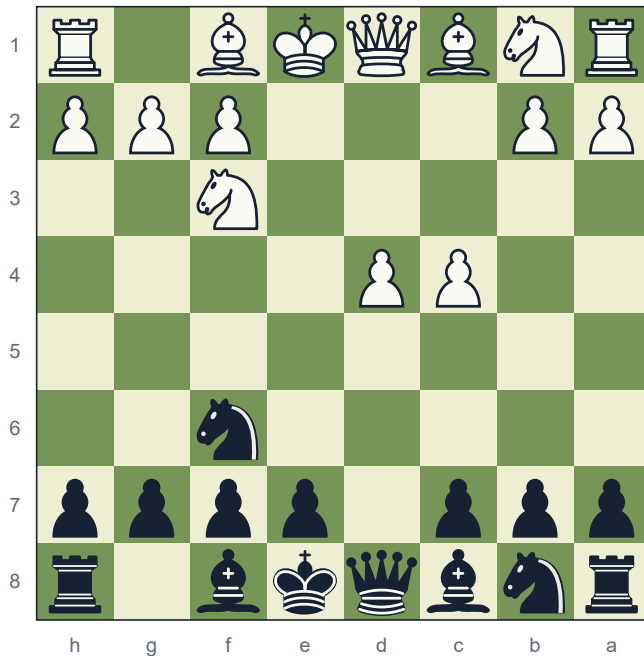
REMEMBER Use the time White gives you to develop.

SC-19 / White attacks the queen with 3.c4

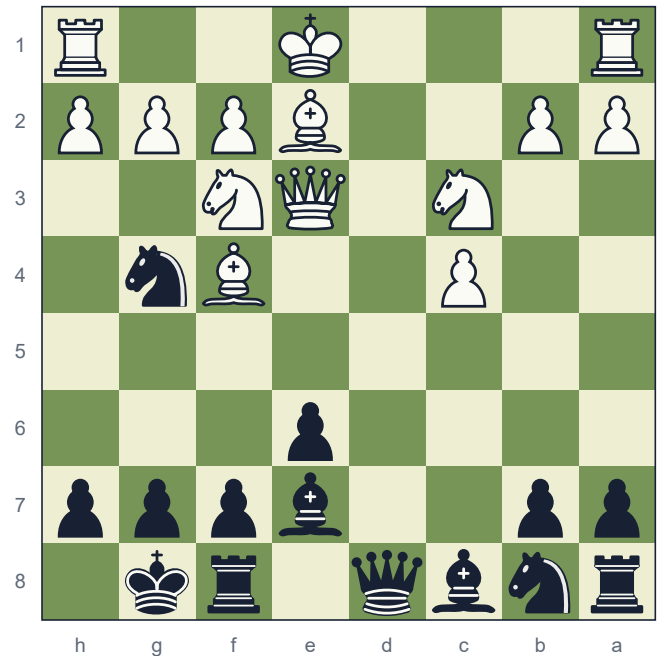
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. c4 Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 e6 6. Nc3 c5 7. Be2 cxd4 8. Qxd4 Be7 9. Bf4 O-O 10. Qe3 Ng4

Authored anchor ends after 5... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The c-pawn move gains a queen tempo but leaves d4 as a possible long-term target. Black retreats safely and develops.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops and seek ...c5 or ...Bb4+ when appropriate. Study an isolated d-pawn structure if central exchanges leave White with one.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White has space and easy development. Trying to punish c4 immediately can be worse than accepting a normal position.

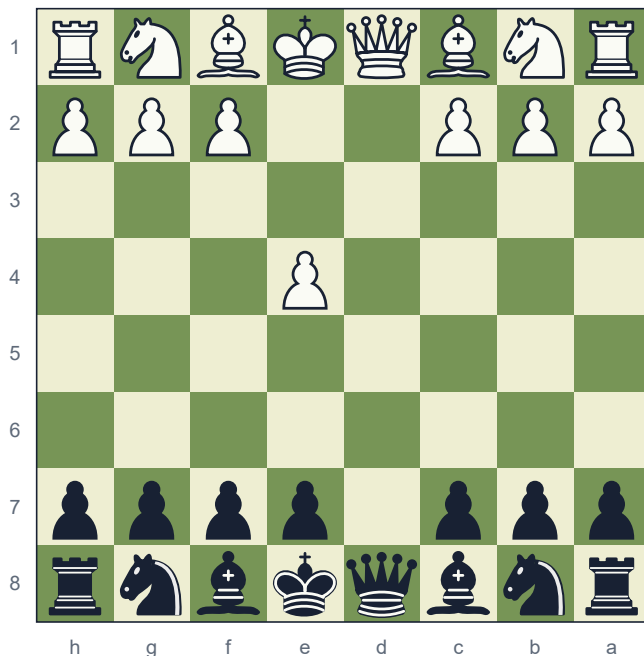
REMEMBER A pawn tempo also changes the pawn structure.

SC-20 / White uses 2.d3

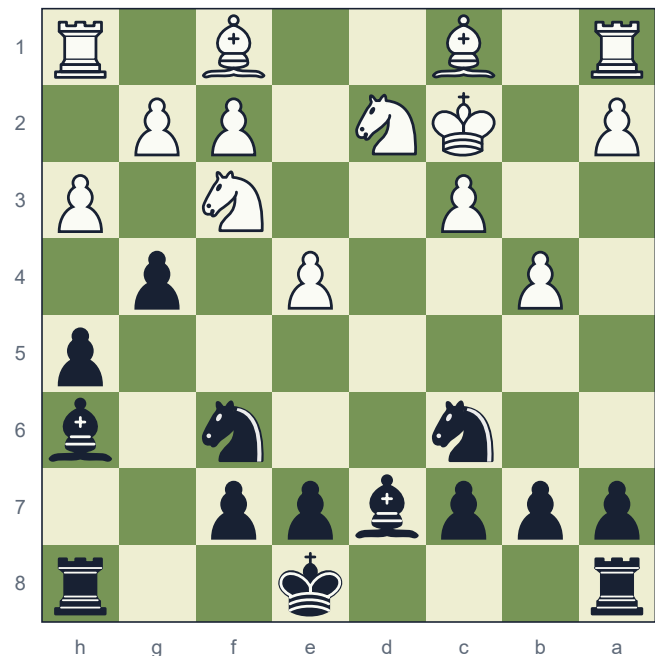
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. d3 dxe4 3. dxe4 Qxd1+ 4. Kxd1 Nc6 5. Nd2 Nf6 6. c3 g5 7. Kc2 h5 8. h3 Bh6 9. Ngf3 Bd7 10. b4 g4

Authored anchor ends after 4. Kxd1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The early exchange permits a queen trade and removes White's castling rights. With queens gone, the centralized white king is less exposed than it would be in a middlegame.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop rapidly and target e4 if it is weak. Use the king-safety lead as a development opportunity rather than expecting a mating attack without queens.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can consolidate with Bd3 and Ke2. Do not overestimate a lost castling right in a simplified position.

REMEMBER Queenless king safety is a different calculation.

Work through SC-13

7... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

8... NF5

Places the knight on f5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... B5

Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10... BXB5

The bishop captures a pawn on b5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure. Develop the king side and decide whether ...e6 or ...Bg4 best fits White's setup. Attack the pawn chain rather than automatically bringing the queen out.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Optional queen and knight recaptures

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-21 - Returning the queen avoids repeated queen attacks but concedes a clear developing tempo. This is an optional alternative, not a move to mix into an existing ...Qa5 position.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can use Ne5 or d5 while Black is still developing. The queen's safety alone does not solve the space problem.

RECOGNITION TEST

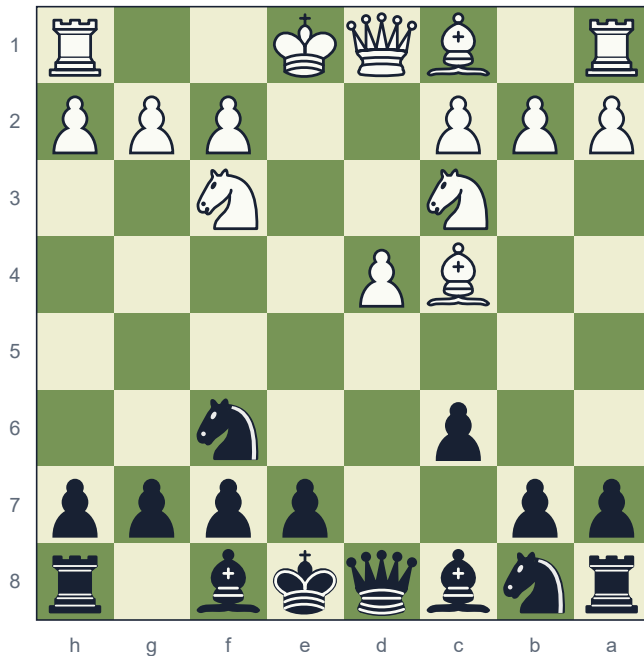
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-21 / Optional ...Qd8 repertoire

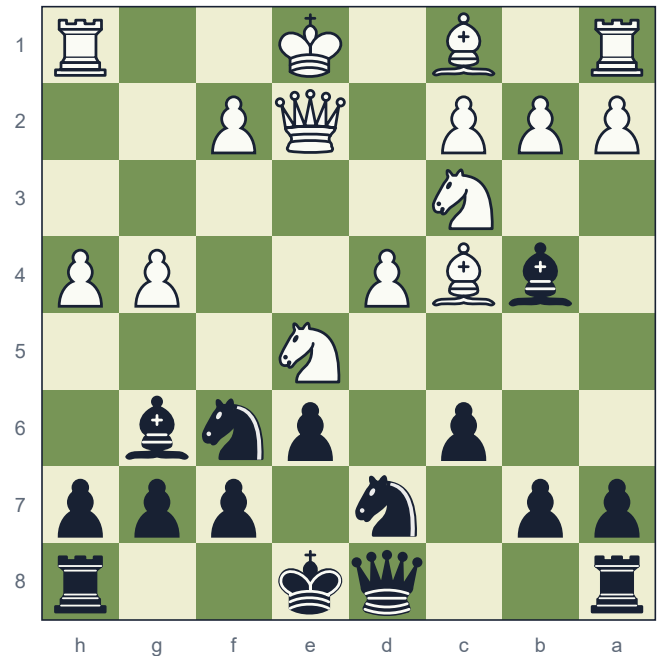
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Ne5 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4 Nbd7 10. Qe2 Bb4

Authored anchor ends after 6... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Returning the queen avoids repeated queen attacks but concedes a clear developing tempo. This is an optional alternative, not a move to mix into an existing ...Qa5 position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Ne5 or d5 while Black is still developing. The queen's safety alone does not solve the space problem.

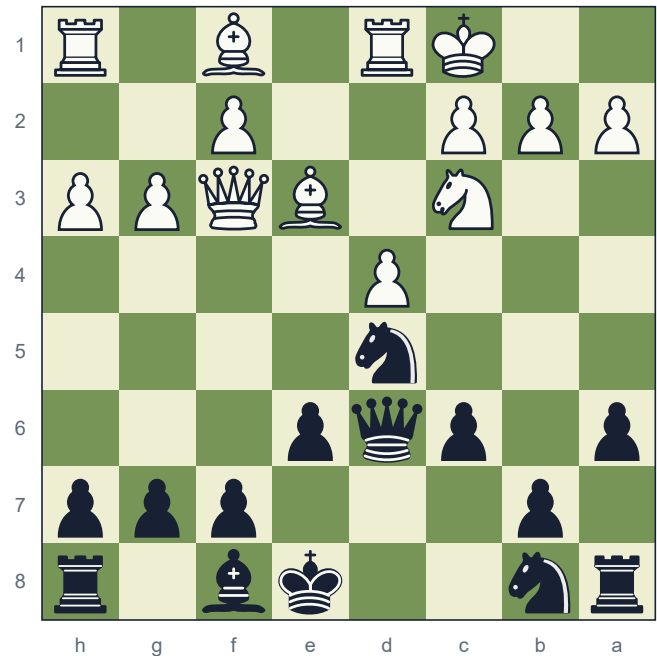
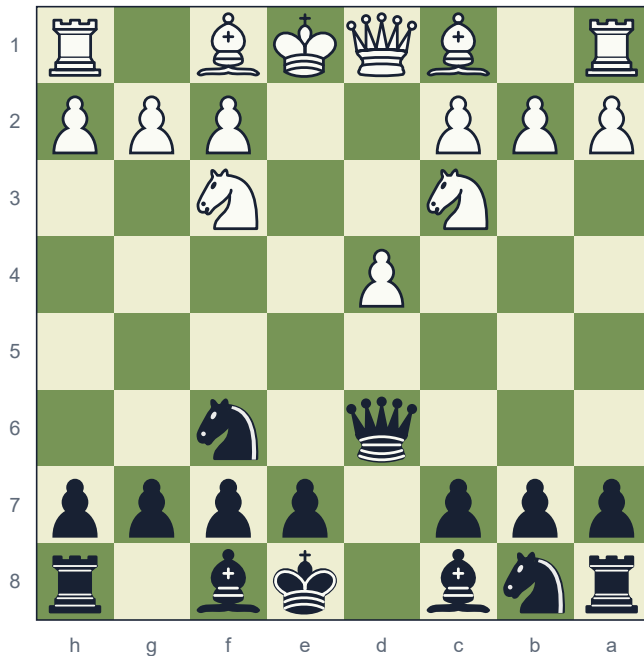
REMEMBER A safe queen still leaves a development debt.

SC-22 / Optional ...Qd6 repertoire

OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd6 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 a6 6. g3 Bg4 7. h3 Bxf3 8. Qxf3 c6 9. Be3 e6 10. O-O-O Nd5

Authored anchor ends after 5... a6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

The queen on d6 supports the center but can be targeted by Ne4, Bf4 or later central moves. ...a6 keeps Nb5 under control.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop with a clear plan for ...b5 or ...Nc6 when appropriate. Decide on the queen bishop before fixing the e-pawn.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Every pawn tempo delays king safety. White can build pressure quickly if the queen and king both remain exposed.

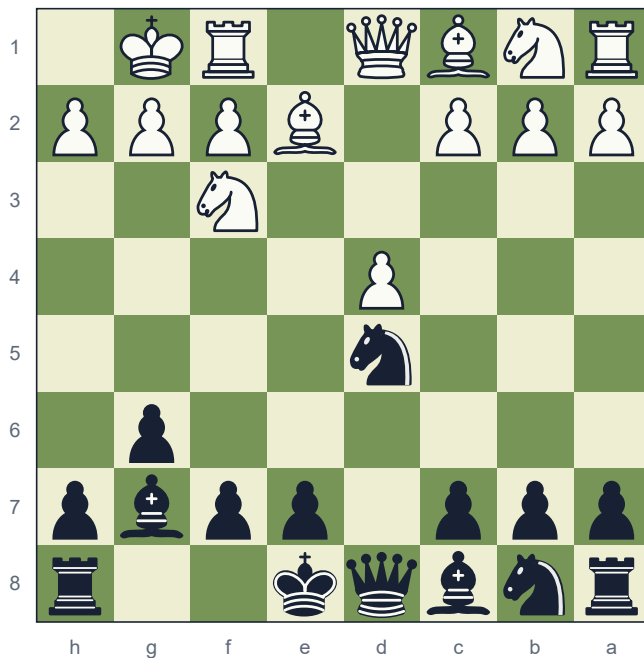
REMEMBER The queen's square determines which knight jumps matter.

SC-23 / Optional 2...Nf6: recover with a knight

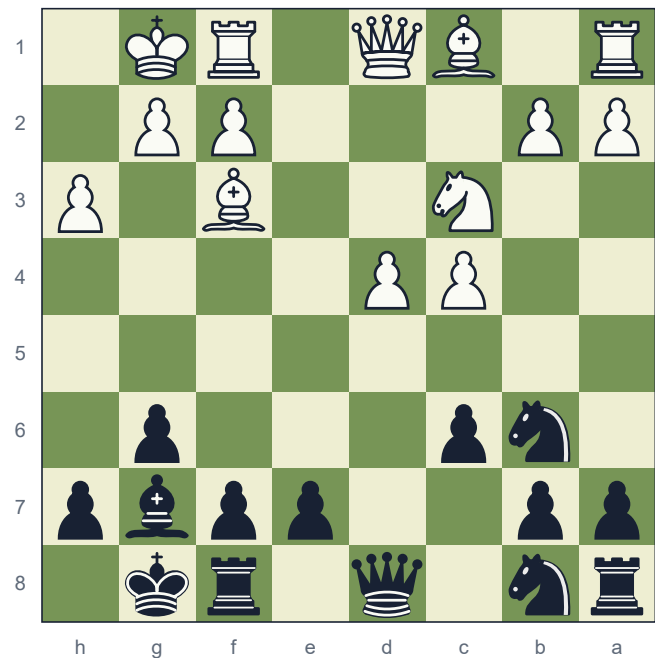
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Nf6 3. d4 Nxd5 4. Nf3 g6 5. Be2 Bg7 6. O-O O-O 7. c4 Nb6 8. Nc3 Bg4 9. h3 Bxf3 10. Bxf3 c6

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black delays recapturing and then uses the knight. The fianchetto creates a different repertoire from the queen-recapture Scandinavian.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen knight and challenge d4 with ...c5. Keep the d5 knight safe from c4 and central exchanges.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may gain tempi with c4. A knight recapture avoids queen attacks but does not eliminate attacks on the recapturing piece.

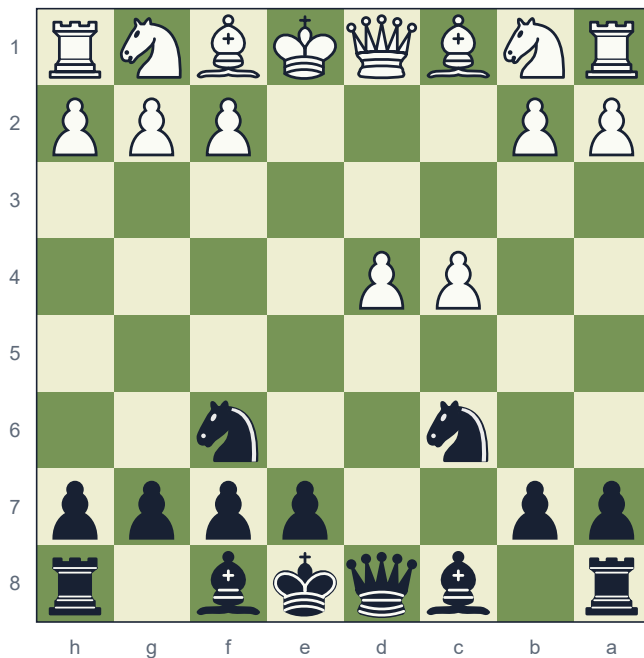
REMEMBER Different recapture, different development plan.

SC-24 / Against 3.c4 after ...Nf6

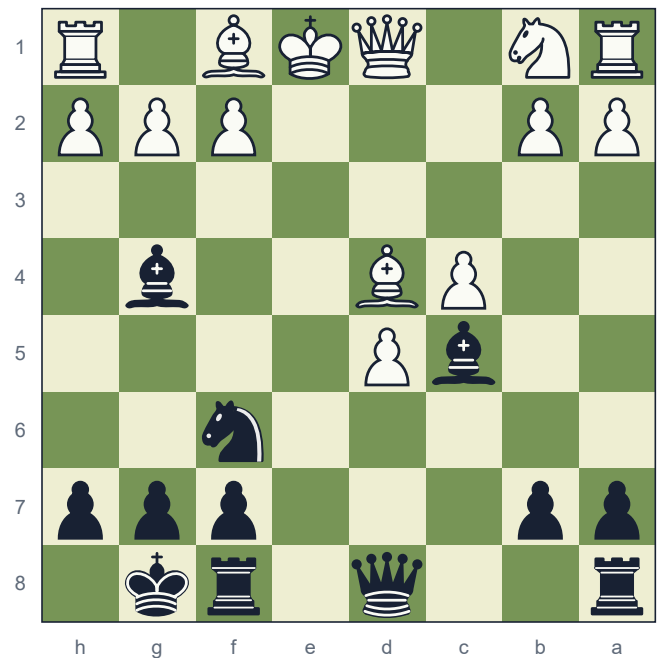
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Nf6 3. c4 c6 4. dxc6 Nxc6 5. d4 e5 6. d5 Bc5 7. Be3 Nd4 8. Nf3 O-O 9. Nxd4 exd4 10. Bxd4 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 5... e5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black offers a second pawn to gain development and central activity. This is an optional gambit branch requiring exact calculation, not part of the main ...Qa5 course repertoire.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop actively and look for central pressure rather than trying to regain the pawn with slow moves. Compare this risk with the direct queen-recapture repertoire.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can consolidate extra material. A gambit is not justified by development alone if no concrete pressure follows.

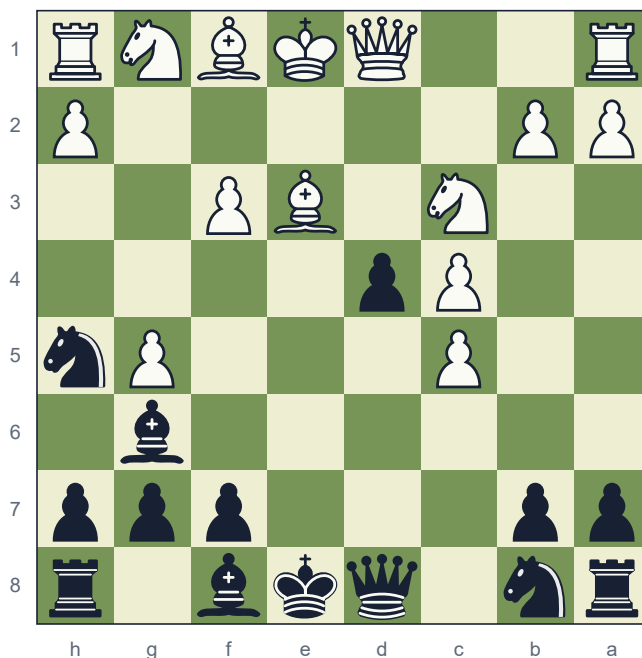
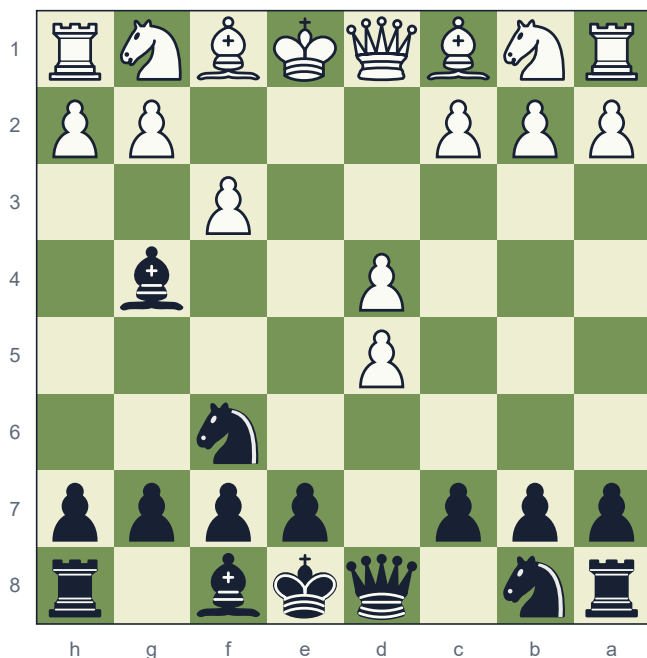
REMEMBER Choose a gambit knowingly, with a follow-up.

SC-25 / Portuguese-style development

OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Nf6 3. d4 Bg4 4. f3 Bf5 5. g4 Bg6 6. c4 e6 7. Nc3 c5 8. Be3 exd5 9. g5 Nh5 10. dxc5 d4

Authored anchor ends after 4... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black delays recapturing again to develop the bishop and provoke f3. White gains a center but has weakened dark squares.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate central blows and develop rapidly. The bishop retreat must preserve activity while the d5 pawn remains unresolved.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may hold the pawn and build a powerful center. Treat this as advanced optional material after mastering the main repertoire.

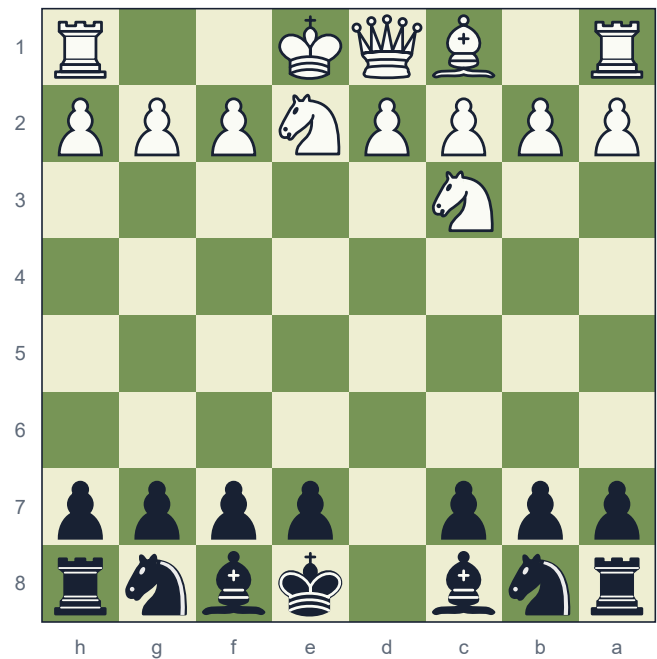
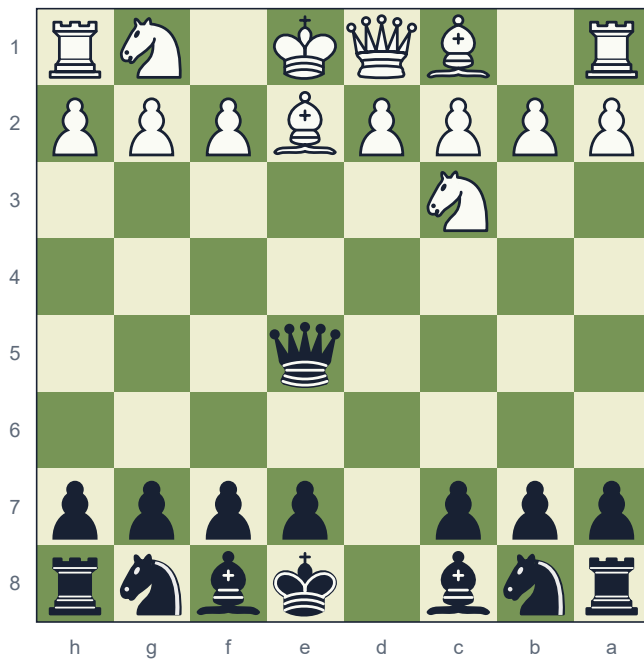
REMEMBER Provoking a weakness is useful only if you can use it.

SC-26 / Warning: the queen blunder

WARNING LINE - study the mistake

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qe5+ 4. Be2 Qxe2+ 5. Ngxe2

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



WHY THIS BRANCH

The queen's check does not make a capture on e2 safe. White's g1 knight can recapture, and Black has lost the queen for a bishop.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Reconstruct the legal knight move and explain why a check was not a shield. In real games, retreat the queen rather than continuing an unsound raid.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A forcing-looking sequence can still end with the attacking queen trapped or exchanged at a huge loss.

REMEMBER A check does not suspend the opponent's legal captures.

Work through SC-21

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... BG6

Places the bishop on g6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... NBD7

Places the knight on d7, attacking knight on e5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... BB4

Places the bishop on b4, attacking knight on c3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Returning the queen avoids repeated queen attacks but concedes a clear developing tempo. This is an optional alternative, not a move to mix into an existing ...Qa5 position. Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.